

Fokker D.VII

“We got into a dogfight with the new brand of Fokkers... we put up the best fight of our lives, but these Huns were just too good for us.”

LIEUTENANT JOHN M. GRIDER
BRITISH PILOT'S DIARY ENTRY ON FIRST
ENCOUNTERING THE FOKKER D.VII

By 1918, German pilots were desperate for a single-seat fighter to replace their outdated Albatroses and Fokker Dr.I triplanes. After evaluation trials held at Adlershof, Berlin, at the end of January, the Fokker D.VII was selected for mass production, and the first models arrived at the front the following April.

Hard-pressed Jastas (fighter squadrons) greeted their new mounts with relief and enthusiasm. German pilot Rudolf Stark wrote: “The machines climb wonderfully and respond to the slightest movement of the controls.” Their impact on the fighting peaked during the summer of 1918, by which time some 40 Jastas were flying D.VIIs, many of them with BMW engines that gave substantially better performance than the original Mercedes power plants. Operating in skies crowded with Allied

aircraft of all kinds, D.VII pilots achieved exceptional kill rates. For example, one squadron, Jasta Boelcke, scored 46 confirmed victories in a month with the loss of only two of its own pilots.

The BMW-powered D.VII was especially effective at high altitude – its pilots were among the first to be issued with experimental oxygen equipment, as well as parachutes. Flying high gave the D.VII the initial advantage in encounters with Allied fighters and also allowed it to hunt down the Allied reconnaissance aircraft, which depended on altitude for safety. About 1,500 D.VIIs were delivered before the end of the war in November 1918.

Fabric-covered
plywood decking on
top of rear fuselage

Coloured
“lozenges”

Fixed stirrup aids
entry into cockpit

Louvers aid engine cooling

COLORFUL CAMOUFLAGE

Most D.VIIs were delivered with this imaginative camouflage print, with patterns of irregular, colored “lozenges.” When viewed from a distance these lozenges merged to form an effective camouflage.

Scalloped trailing edge formed by
taut wire linking ends of ribs

Radiator
filler tube

Aluminum panels cover
nose of aircraft

Wire-spoked wheels
with fabric covers

